GREENING INDIA'S HIGHWAYS

Highways are a success story of the Modi government, but high road deaths, project delays and air pollution rob some sheen

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The Union ministry of road transport and highways has been one of the crowning achievements of the Modi government, with significant progress in the building of new highways and greenfield expressways across India. The legal framework governing the transport sector and road safety underwent a major overhaul with the Motor Vehicles Amendment Act in 2019. But all of this good work is undone by the inability to reduce road deaths and crashes, where India continues to top global lists. The coming years will require the government to address the slowdown of projects and missed deadlines. Improving the financial health of its premier highway-building agency, the National Highways Authority of India, will also be a top priority. The agency is burdened by a colossal debt of over Rs 3.4 lakh crore. A large portion of its funds goes into servicing this debt, leaving it with little wriggle room for investments in new projects. The government has several plans to ease this burden in the next few years, one of which is to issue Infrastructure Investment Trusts to take funds from investors and invest in profitable projects. Moreover, the ministry also has ambitious plans to roll out innovative tech. These include implementing GPS-based, contactless toll collection on highways and establishing electric corridors for trucks. These initiatives aim to modernise India's road infrastructure and improve efficiency, but how well and how soon they can be implemented will be criticial to their success. The Modi government's third term will be tested on the viability of these promises and if it can translate them into tangible outcomes. ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

MEET TARGETS

The highways sector has seen substantial growth with the Bharatmala Pariyojana, aimed at enhancing road infrastructure. The new government should accelerate construction to meet the target of 34,800 km of National Highway length sanctioned in the first phase. There may be a need to review the financing models

ENSURE SAFETY

With higher permissible speeds on highways, addressing engineering flaws and ensuring quality maintenance is vital for road safety. India holds the top spot internationally for annual road-crash fatalities. Over 150,000 road users die in the country every year. India, like many other countries, has for long been chasing the target of reducing deaths by 50 per cent. The current target is 2030. Apart from awareness, stricter implementation of the laws, especially in Tier II and III cities, and deep engineering solutions of road infrastructure will be key

EASE URBAN MOBILITY

Last-mile connectivity continues to be a bane. Collaboration with state governments is essential to create effective solutions. This approach not only improves urban mobility but also contributes to better air quality and overall public health